

DIGESTIVE ANATOMY

THE DIGESTIVE TRACT AND ITS ASSOCIATED ORGANS, INCLUDING THE LIVER, GALLBLADDER, AND PANCREAS, BREAK DOWN FOOD, EXTRACT NUTRIENTS, AND DISPOSE OF WASTE MATERIALS.

After being eaten, or ingested, food embarks on a journey. It can take up to 24 hours to cover a distance of 9m (30ft), through various muscular tubes and chambers. The process begins at the mouth, where food is crushed and ground down by the teeth during chewing. The resulting ball, or bolus, of food continues down the throat (pharynx), then travels through the gullet (oesophagus) to the stomach, small intestine, large intestine, and anus. In the small intestine, chemicals break down food into molecules small enough to absorb into the blood. What cannot be digested is compacted as faeces in the large intestine and eliminated through the anus. Food travels through the system by a process of muscular contraction called peristalsis. The digestive system includes several glands: the spit-making salivary glands; the pancreas, which produces powerful digestive juices; and the body's major nutrient processor, the liver.

